

The national accounts inkblot test

#australia

#luciellis

#bonds

#housing

#interestrates



By Luci Ellis

Chief Economist Westpac Group, Westpac

16:30 September 04 2026

 Share

A story-driven species encounters national accounts data that resist easy narratives.



- In something as complex as an economy, outcomes often defy simple narratives. It is a little like those inkblot psychology tests one sometimes sees. Is it a rabbit or is it a lady? It depends on your perspective.

- The national accounts for Q2 2026 were a case in point. A hawkish take would focus on GDP growth being above RBA expectations and not below its view of trend; a dovish take would focus on the loss of momentum more recently. Likewise a hawk could point to the outsized July CPI print, while the dove can remind you of the noise and uncertain seasonality in the monthly data. Both narratives inherently leave out contradicting signals.
- The key issue here is to make sure that you are taking signal from all the available data, not just the things that fit the narrative. Labour market data deserve more consideration than some observers are giving them. Also important is remembering that the next quarter will always be thrown about by special factors, and what matters is where things are in a year or so's time.

In something as complex as an economy, there are always many things going on, not all pointing in the same direction. There will be headwinds and tailwinds. Most shocks and trends affect some industries and parts of the economy more than others. The overall impact is a complicated netting exercise that is hard to be precise about in the real world, where measurement is uncertain and things get revised.

That complexity sits uncomfortably for a species that shapes its understanding through story. A simple cause-and-effect narrative fits the way our brains have evolved. Messy outcomes like this week's national accounts (and the domestic data flow more broadly) do not fit simple stories. It is tempting for people to extract one nonetheless. The process resembles one of those old psychology tricks where you can see a rabbit or a woman, a face or a vase, depending on your perspective, or the Rorschach inkblot where you can "see" what you want to see. We pattern-match, we see creatures in the clouds – and sometimes, we can be selective with data when we should not be, focusing only on what fits our narrative.

I am not going to pretend to be above reproach on this front, being a member of the same narrative-seeking species as everyone else. That said, I cannot help noticing how easy it is to squint at the economic inkblot and see a hawk or a dove according to one's prior beliefs.

Those seeing the hawk will point to (among other things) the 2.1%yr GDP growth being above the RBA's forecast and not below its estimate of potential output growth "speed limit", as the RBA is trying to engineer. They will note the tick-up in unit labour cost growth, resilient consumption, strong data centre investment and – beyond the national accounts – the outsized July CPI inflation data. Putting these together, a narrative forms that seemingly demands immediate further tightening of monetary policy.

In doing so, though, one would need to leave a few things out. Among these are the fact that growth stepped down noticeably through the year, and that about half the upside surprise in year-ended growth was a revision to an earlier quarter, implying you got more growth for the same amount of inflation. Also downplayed in this narrative is the weak growth in average earnings per hour – a less-noisy input into unit labour costs – the increase in household saving and the roll-off in public sector investment making room for higher dwelling and data centre investment.

And for those confidently expecting a September hike, it requires a belief that the RBA will go back on their previous statement that, in this initial phase, they will focus on the quarterly inflation data rather

than a new monthly series with its short history and uncertain seasonality that is prone to revision. (And the RBA might well go back on that commitment, but one must explicitly believe it will.)

The same exercise of leaving pieces out to make a neater story also permeates the dove case. One could highlight that the 2.1% year-ended GDP growth rate was comprised of two halves, with the most recent showing much weaker growth in domestic demand. One can point to the larger-than-expected downturn in the housing market, weak per capita growth, moderate consumption outside a few special factors such as EV purchases, and the likely run of monthly trimmed mean CPI prints from here being noticeably below the July figure.

This narrative also requires leaving a few things out, though. As well as the components of the hawk case already noted, there is the issue that the data centre boom could well offset the receding public sector's release of construction resources.

Part of the difficulty is that the narratives we seek can be so black-and-white binary. It is also embedded in the here and now, immediate data flow. We should ask ourselves whether we should really take so much signal from small surprises in the latest data. The crucial question is what these noisy outcomes mean for the underlying trends, and where growth and inflation will be in a year or so.

We also note that much of the recent discussion has made relatively little of the labour market. It has been easing over much of the past year or so (contra the RBA's initial assessment earlier this year that it was re-tightening) and is noticeably softer than RBA expectations. Today's labour accounts confirm that more people have taken on secondary jobs to address cost-of-living pressures. Labour supply, both in terms of the number of people in the labour force and the number of hours they want to work, has been more resilient than many observers expected. The various measures of underemployment are pointing to emerging spare capacity that might not be widely recognised.

What is the resolution, if any? Structured analysis including whole-economy models is one way through the difficulty, but it relies on the models being a decent representation of reality. Perhaps another, honouring the fact our brains evolved to want simple stories, is to emulate Charles Darwin and systematically note down any piece of evidence against your current theory. It might make it harder to tell a simple story, but it will mean you are less likely to miss something that later turns out to be important.

Stay informed with Westpac IQ

Get the latest reports straight to your inbox.

Subscribe



#australia

Australia and NZ Weekly 14 September 2026

September 14 2026 • ⌚ 10 mins

By [Luci Ellis](#), [Matthew Hassan](#), [Elliot Clarke](#) & [10 more](#)



#australia

Australia and NZ Weekly 14 September 2026

September 11 2026 • ⌚ 10 mins

By [Luci Ellis](#), [Matthew Hassan](#), [Elliot Clarke](#) & [10 more](#)



#australia

Australia and NZ Weekly 7 September 2026

September 07 2026 • ⌚ 10 mins

By [Luci Ellis](#), [Matthew Hassan](#), [Elliot Clarke](#) & [10 more](#)

Browse topics

- #aud
- #australia
- #interestrates
- #nzd
- #usd
- #newzealand
- #rates
- #credit
- #yieldcurve
- #acgb
- #inflation
- #semigovernment
- #rba
- #basis
- #commodities
- #ustreasury
- #fx
- #jpy
- #rbnz
- #abs
- Show more tags

Disclaimer

©2026 Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 (including where acting under any of its Westpac, St George, Bank of Melbourne or BankSA brands, collectively, “Westpac”). References to the “Westpac Group” are to Westpac and its subsidiaries and includes the directors, employees and representatives of Westpac and its subsidiaries.

Things you should know

We respect your privacy: You can view the [New Zealand Privacy Policy](#) here, or the [Australian Group Privacy Statement](#) here. Each time someone visits our site, data is captured so that we can accurately evaluate the quality of our content and make improvements for you. We may at times use technology to capture data about you to help us to better understand you and your needs, including potentially for the purposes of assessing your individual reading habits and interests to allow us to provide suggestions regarding other reading material which may be suitable for you.

This information, unless specifically indicated otherwise, is under copyright of the Westpac Group. None of the material, nor its contents, nor any copy of it, may be altered in any way, transmitted to, copied or distributed to any other party without the prior written permission of the Westpac Group.

Disclaimer

This information has been prepared by Westpac and is intended for information purposes only. It is not intended to reflect any recommendation or financial advice and investment decisions should not be based on it. This information does not constitute an offer, a solicitation of an offer, or an inducement to subscribe for, purchase or sell any financial instrument or to enter into a legally binding contract. To the extent that this information contains any general advice, it has been prepared without taking into account your objectives, financial situation or needs and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the advice. Certain types of transactions, including those involving futures, options and high yield securities give rise to substantial risk and are not suitable for all investors. We recommend that you seek your own independent legal or financial advice before proceeding with any investment decision.

This information may contain material provided by third parties. While such material is published with the necessary permission none of Westpac or its related entities accepts any responsibility for the accuracy or completeness of any such material. Although we have made every effort to ensure this information is free from error, none of Westpac or its related entities warrants the accuracy, adequacy or completeness of this information, or otherwise endorses it in any way. Except where contrary to law, Westpac Group intend by this notice to exclude liability for this information. This information is subject to change without notice and none of Westpac or its related entities is under any obligation to update this information or correct any inaccuracy which may become apparent at a later date. This information may contain or incorporate by reference forward-looking statements. The words “believe”, “anticipate”, “expect”, “intend”, “plan”, “predict”, “continue”, “assume”, “positioned”, “may”, “will”, “should”, “shall”, “risk” and other similar expressions that are predictions of or indicate future events and future trends identify forward-looking statements. These forward-

looking statements include all matters that are not historical facts. Past performance is not a reliable indicator of future performance, nor are forecasts of future performance. Whilst every effort has been taken to ensure that the assumptions on which any forecasts are based are reasonable, the forecasts may be affected by incorrect assumptions or by known or unknown risks and uncertainties. The ultimate outcomes may differ substantially from any forecasts.

Conflicts of Interest: In the normal course of offering banking products and services to its clients, the Westpac Group may act in several capacities (including issuer, market maker, underwriter, distributor, swap counterparty and calculation agent) simultaneously with respect to a financial instrument, giving rise to potential conflicts of interest which may impact the performance of a financial instrument. The Westpac Group may at any time transact or hold a position (including hedging and trading positions) for its own account or the account of a client in any financial instrument which may impact the performance of that financial instrument.

Author(s) disclaimer and declaration: The author(s) confirms that (a) no part of his/her compensation was, is, or will be, directly or indirectly, related to any views or (if applicable) recommendations expressed in this material; (b) this material accurately reflects his/her personal views about the financial products, companies or issuers (if applicable) and is based on sources reasonably believed to be reliable and accurate; (c) to the best of the author's knowledge, they are not in receipt of inside information and this material does not contain inside information; and (d) no other part of the Westpac Group has made any attempt to influence this material.

Further important information regarding sustainability-related content: This material may contain statements relating to environmental, social and governance (ESG) topics. These are subject to known and unknown risks, and there are significant uncertainties, limitations, risks and assumptions in the metrics, modelling, data, scenarios, reporting and analysis on which the statements rely. In particular, these areas are rapidly evolving and maturing, and there are variations in approaches and common standards and practice, as well as uncertainty around future related policy and legislation. Some material may include information derived from publicly available sources that have not been independently verified. No representation or warranty is made as to the accuracy, completeness or reliability of the information. There is a risk that the analysis, estimates, judgements, assumptions, views, models, scenarios or projections used may turn out to be incorrect. These risks may cause actual outcomes to differ materially from those expressed or implied. The ESG-related statements in this material do not constitute advice, nor are they guarantees or predictions of future performance, and Westpac gives no representation, warranty or assurance (including as to the quality, accuracy or completeness of the statements). You should seek your own independent advice.

Additional country disclosures:

Australia: Westpac holds an Australian Financial Services Licence (No. 233714). You can access Westpac's Financial Services Guide [here](#) or request a copy from your Westpac point of contact. To the extent that this information contains any general advice, it has been prepared without taking into account your objectives, financial situation or needs and before acting on it you should consider the

appropriateness of the advice.

New Zealand: In New Zealand, Westpac Institutional Bank refers to the brand under which products and services are provided by either Westpac (NZ division) or Westpac New Zealand Limited (company number 1763882), the New Zealand incorporated subsidiary of Westpac ("WNZL"). Any product or service made available by WNZL does not represent an offer from Westpac or any of its subsidiaries (other than WNZL). Neither Westpac nor its other subsidiaries guarantee or otherwise support the performance of WNZL in respect of any such product. WNZL is not an authorised deposit-taking institution for the purposes of Australian prudential standards. The current disclosure statements for the New Zealand branch of Westpac and WNZL can be obtained at the internet address www.westpac.co.nz.

Singapore: This material has been prepared and issued for distribution in Singapore to institutional investors, accredited investors and expert investors (as defined in the applicable Singapore laws and regulations) only. Recipients of this material in Singapore should contact Westpac Singapore Branch in respect of any matters arising from, or in connection with, this material. Westpac Singapore Branch holds a wholesale banking licence and is subject to supervision by the Monetary Authority of Singapore.

Fiji: Unless otherwise specified, the products and services for Westpac Fiji are available from www.westpac.com.fj © Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141. This information does not take your personal circumstances into account and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the information for your financial situation. Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 is incorporated in NSW Australia and registered as a branch in Fiji. The liability of its members is limited.

Papua New Guinea: Unless otherwise specified, the products and services for Westpac PNG are available from www.westpac.com.pg © Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141. This information does not take your personal circumstances into account and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the information for your financial situation. Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 is incorporated in NSW Australia. Westpac is represented in Papua New Guinea by Westpac Bank - PNG - Limited. The liability of its members is limited.

U.S.: Westpac operates in the United States of America as a federally licensed branch, regulated by the Office of the Comptroller of the Currency. Westpac is also registered with the US Commodity Futures Trading Commission ("CFTC") as a Swap Dealer, but is neither registered as, or affiliated with, a Futures Commission Merchant registered with the US CFTC. The services and products referenced above are not insured by the Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation ("FDIC"). Westpac Capital Markets, LLC ('WCM'), a wholly-owned subsidiary of Westpac, is a broker-dealer registered under the U.S. Securities Exchange Act of 1934 ('the Exchange Act') and member of the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority ('FINRA'). In accordance with APRA's Prudential Standard 222 'Association with Related Entities', Westpac does not stand behind WCM other than as provided for in certain legal agreements between Westpac and WCM and obligations of WCM do not represent

liabilities of Westpac.

This communication is provided for distribution to U.S. institutional investors in reliance on the exemption from registration provided by Rule 15a-6 under the Exchange Act and is not subject to all of the independence and disclosure standards applicable to debt research reports prepared for retail investors in the United States. WCM is the U.S. distributor of this communication and accepts responsibility for the contents of this communication. Transactions by U.S. customers of any securities referenced herein should be effected through WCM. All disclaimers set out with respect to Westpac apply equally to WCM. If you would like to speak to someone regarding any security mentioned herein, please contact WCM on +1 212 389 1269. Investing in any non-U.S. securities or related financial instruments mentioned in this communication may present certain risks. The securities of non-U.S. issuers may not be registered with, or be subject to the regulations of, the SEC in the United States. Information on such non-U.S. securities or related financial instruments may be limited. Non-U.S. companies may not be subject to audit and reporting standards and regulatory requirements comparable to those in effect in the United States. The value of any investment or income from any securities or related derivative instruments denominated in a currency other than U.S. dollars is subject to exchange rate fluctuations that may have a positive or adverse effect on the value of or income from such securities or related derivative instruments.

The author of this communication is employed by Westpac and is not registered or qualified as a research analyst, representative, or associated person of WCM or any other U.S. broker-dealer under the rules of FINRA, any other U.S. self-regulatory organisation, or the laws, rules or regulations of any State. Unless otherwise specifically stated, the views expressed herein are solely those of the author and may differ from the information, views or analysis expressed by Westpac and/or its affiliates.

UK: The London branch of Westpac is authorised in the United Kingdom by the Prudential Regulation Authority (PRA) and is subject to regulation by the Financial Conduct Authority (FCA) and limited regulation by the PRA (Financial Services Register number: 124586). The London branch of Westpac is registered at Companies House as a branch established in the United Kingdom (Branch No. BR000106). Details about the extent of the regulation of Westpac's London branch by the PRA are available from us on request.

This communication is not being made to or distributed to, and must not be passed on to, the general public in the United Kingdom. Rather, this communication is being made only to and is directed at (a) those persons falling within the definition of Investment Professionals (set out in Article 19(5) of the Financial Services and Markets Act 2000 (Financial Promotion) Order 2005 (the "Order")); (b) those persons falling within the definition of high net worth companies, unincorporated associations etc. (set out in Article 49(2) of the Order; (c) other persons to whom it may lawfully be communicated in accordance with the Order or (d) any persons to whom it may otherwise lawfully be made (all such persons together being referred to as "relevant persons"). Any person who is not a relevant person should not act or rely on this communication or any of its contents. In the same way, the information contained in this communication is intended for "eligible counterparties" and

“professional clients” as defined by the rules of the Financial Conduct Authority and is not intended for “retail clients”. Westpac expressly prohibits you from passing on the information in this communication to any third party.

European Economic Area (“EEA”): This material may be distributed to you by either: (i) Westpac directly, or (ii) Westpac Europe GmbH (“WEG”) under a sub-licensing arrangement. WEG has not edited or otherwise modified the content of this material. WEG is authorised in Germany by the Federal Financial Supervision Authority (‘BaFin’) and subject to its regulation. WEG’s supervisory authorities are BaFin and the German Federal Bank (‘Deutsche Bundesbank’). WEG is registered with the commercial register (‘Handelsregister’) of the local court of Frankfurt am Main under registration number HRB 118483. In accordance with APRA’s Prudential Standard 222 ‘Association with Related Entities’, Westpac does not stand behind WEG other than as provided for in certain legal agreements (a risk transfer, sub-participation and collateral agreement) between Westpac and WEG and obligations of WEG do not represent liabilities of Westpac. Any product or service made available by WEG does not represent an offer from Westpac or any of its subsidiaries (other than WEG). All disclaimers set out with respect to Westpac apply equally to WEG.

This communication is not intended for distribution to, or use by any person or entity in any jurisdiction or country where such distribution or use would be contrary to local law or regulation.

This communication contains general commentary, research, and market colour. The communication does not constitute investment advice. The material may contain an ‘investment recommendation’ and/or ‘information recommending or suggesting an investment’, both as defined in Regulation (EU) No 596/2014 (including as applicable in the United Kingdom) (“MAR”). In accordance with the relevant provisions of MAR, reasonable care has been taken to ensure that the material has been objectively presented and that interests or conflicts of interest of the sender concerning the financial instruments to which that information relates have been disclosed.

Investment recommendations must be read alongside the specific disclosure which accompanies them and the general disclosure which can be found [here](#). Such disclosure fulfils certain additional information requirements of MAR and associated delegated legislation and by accepting this communication you acknowledge that you are aware of the existence of such additional disclosure and its contents.

To the extent this communication comprises an investment recommendation it is classified as non-independent research. It has not been prepared in accordance with legal requirements designed to promote the independence of investment research and therefore constitutes a marketing communication. Further, this communication is not subject to any prohibition on dealing ahead of the dissemination of investment research.